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SESSION — Nov 12 & 13

10 · 50 · 10

Skill Docs, with Quals in View



GOAL —

Participants build two reusable configurations: a "RAND analyst" skill (style, citation conventions, standard caveats, preferred workflows) and a "qual study partner" skill that quizzes them from their own readings without inventing anything. Both are files the model loads every time.

WHY —

Everything the group has learned lives in people's heads and the Playbook. A skill document puts it in the model's context on demand. It's also the closest thing to institutional memory a chat tool has. With quals two weeks out, the study-partner skill is the most immediately useful thing the group can build, and it exercises every rule from Sessions 1 through 4.

READY-MADE MATERIALS —

Use these when nobody has their own. Everything here is public or was written for this course.

Starter RAND analyst skill doc, for the room to edit

```
# RAND analyst
Use when: drafting any RAND memo, brief, or summary.
Reader: a policy generalist with ten minutes.
Format: headers no deeper than three levels. Page-cite every factual claim as (Author, p. X).
Always: flag uncertainty. Separate what the source says from what you infer.
Never: invent a statistic. Resolve a conflict between sources without flagging it.
Lit review: extract claims to a table first, synthesize second.
```

Starter qual study partner skill doc

```
# Qual study partner
Use when: I am studying for the qualifying exam.
Sources: only the readings I attach. If the answer is not in them, say so.
Mode: quiz me. One question at a time. Do not give the answer until I have attempted it.
After each attempt: what I got right, what I missed, and the page in the reading that covers it.
Never: invent a citation. Agree with a wrong answer. Summarize a reading I have not attached.
```

Test task

The Session 1 rewrite prompt on the GAO report, with and without the analyst skill loaded. Diff the two outputs. For the

study partner: attach one qual reading and ask for five questions; check every page cite.

Plan 90 MINUTES

10

MIN

COLD OPEN

Agentic-vs-manual homework demo.

50

MIN

CORE

1 What a skill doc is 10

A markdown file with instructions the model reads when relevant: who the reader is, what the output looks like, what to always do (page cites), what to never do (invent a number). Shown as a Project system prompt, a style file, or a formal skill folder depending on the tool. Progressive disclosure: a short description tells the model when to load it; the full file loads only then.

2 Draft together 20

Draft the "RAND analyst" skill live in the shared doc, one person driving. Sections: **Audience** (policymaker, researcher, public). **Output conventions** (headers, length, citation format). **Always** (flag uncertainty, cite page, distinguish source claims from inference). **Never** (invent statistics, resolve source conflicts silently, use jargon without defining). **Workflows** (for a lit review, do X then Y). Pull directly from the Playbook.

3 The study partner 10

The room edits the starter qual skill. The rules that matter: only attached readings; quiz mode, one question at a time; page cite with every correction. Everyone attaches one real qual reading and runs it.

4 Load and test 10

Each person installs one of the drafts in their tool and runs a task from earlier in the term with and without it. Did the output change? Where?

10

MIN

DEBRIEF

What did the skill fix? What did it make worse (over-constrained, verbose caveats)? Iterate one round in the Playbook.

HOMEWORK

Write a personal skill doc for your own project, or refine the study partner for your quals. Bring it to the build session; it's your build, or the seed of one.

60

FOR 60 MINUTES

MIN CUT

Skip drafting the analyst skill from scratch; the room edits the starter.
Keep the study partner block.

FACILITATOR
WATCH-OUTS

- Skill docs bloat fast. Keep each draft under one page. The model reads long instructions the way it reads long documents: badly (Session 2).
 - Someone will ask if this is just a long prompt. Sort of, with two differences: it's reusable, and it only loads when relevant, so it doesn't rot every conversation.
 - Security note for the handout: only use skill files you wrote or trust. A skill is instructions the model will follow.
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